

ANIK DUTTA







BOLD AND BEAUTIFUL
Dishes like (clockwise) tiramisu, a variety of shukopan and pork belly skewers, and (lower left) a cocktail called Noveau Nectar

RESTAURANTS ▼

Haute TABLES

Sahil Sambhi is elevating the Indian restaurant scene with bigger and bolder projects

With a background in IT but *an early interest in food*, Sambhi's culinary journey began in 2015 with a bar called Molecule



The water is as deep as the stick you put into it," is an expression restaurateur Sahil Sambhi likes to repeat often. "There's a market for anything you dream to do."

Sambhi's latest venture, Latango—a European restaurant helmed by two chefs from Italy—is his most ambitious yet. Set in Delhi's Epicuria Mall, it's a sprawling space with a triple-decker kitchen, rough-hewn walls and a striking bar counter made of 2,100 pieces of glass stuck together, the fluid shape designed to evoke the Emerald Grotto on the Amalfi coast.

With a background in IT, but an early interest in food and dining out, Sambhi's culinary journey began in 2015 with Molecule, a high-octane bar that has been wildly successful and has outlets across India now. Sambhi's subsequent offerings include a popular Vietnamese restaurant chain, a regional Indian restaurant with an emphasis on open-fire cooking, a contemporary Japanese restaurant—Japonico—that has become the toast of Gurgaon and, close on its heels, this European restaurant with the occasional Japanese flourish.

Latango, featuring homestyle but poshed-up dishes, takes a no-apologies and no-pandering approach, with an extensive menu comprising cold dishes, tapas as well as hearty pastas, pizzas and mains. Octopus salad, grilled bone marrow, yuzu miso black cod—these flavour bombs tick all the boxes. Crafted by Tulleeho along with Dubai's Liquid Alembic, the cocktails are conceptualised as 'liquid letters' from western artists to their Indian counterparts. The Cubist Negroni, for instance, is inspired by an imagined letter from Pablo Picasso to Amrita Sher-Gil.

Sambhi belongs to a crop of bold, young restaurateurs who are venturing into terrain where few would have ventured before. The wind under their sails is a new kind of diner—well travelled, discerning and with, um, capacious pockets. "With Japonico and Latango, I've realised the market is very elevated. It's up to the restaurateurs to raise the bar," says Sambhi.

He's not resting on his laurels. Next up is Nadoo, an elevated south Indian restaurant in collaboration with Chef Shri Bala, in honour of his south Indian mother, and a café-cum-cocktail bar. Looks like Sambhi is just getting the party started. ■

—Amit Dixit